

The Outsiders: Characterization Reference & Workshop Packet

Chapter 1 Study Guide — Comprehensive Profiles, Motivations, & Social Dynamics

Student Name: _____

Date: _____

Class Period: _____

PART 1: THE CURTIS BROTHERS (FAMILY & HOUSEHOLD DYNAMIC)

CHARACTER & ROLE	KEY TRAITS & PHYSICAL DESCRIPTION	INTERNAL & EXTERNAL CONFLICTS
Ponyboy Curtis <i>Age: 14</i> Narrator & Protagonist	• Light-brown hair, greenish-gray eyes. • Loves literature, movies, and sunsets. • Highly intelligent, sensitive, and observant.	Struggles to reconcile his academic potential with his Greaser identity; feels misunderstood by Darry.
Sodapop Curtis <i>Age: 16-17</i> Middle Brother	• Movie-star good looks, dark-gold hair. • Happy-go-lucky, warm, and empathetic. • High school dropout; works at gas station.	Acts as the emotional buffer and peacekeeper between Darry and Ponyboy; struggles with academic failure.
Darrel 'Darry' Curtis <i>Age: 20</i> Legal Guardian / Head of House	• 6'2", broad-shouldered, pale blue eyes. • Strict, hardworking, serious, and mature. • Former high school football captain.	Gave up a college scholarship to work roofing jobs to keep his brothers together after their parents' death.

PART 2: THE GREASER GANG MEMBERS (EXTENDED FAMILY)

MEMBER	CHARACTER PROFILE & PERSONALITY	ROLE IN THE GANG & KEY SYMBOLISM
Johnny Cade <i>Age: 16</i>	Smallest of the gang, dark puppy-dog eyes, jet-black hair. Suffers from extreme hypervigilance due to parental abuse and a severe past beating by Socs.	The 'Gang's Pet' Represents vulnerability and innocence; the entire gang feels a collective duty to protect him.
Dallas 'Dally' Winston <i>Age: 17</i>	Elfish face, high cheekbones, blazing blue eyes, blonde hair. Hardened, bitter, lawless, and tough; spent time in New York gang violence.	The Hardened Survivor Represents raw survival and street-smarts; rejects societal rules to protect himself from pain.
Two-Bit Mathews <i>Age: 18</i>	Oldest of the gang, 6 feet tall, sideburns. Famous for his wisecracks, shoplifting, and carrying a 10-inch switchblade.	The Comedic Relief Uses humor and deflection to keep group morale high in stressful situations.
Steve Randle <i>Age: 17</i>	Tall, lean, thick hair. Highly skilled with cars and mechanics; Sodapop's best friend.	The Outsider within Insiders Views Ponyboy as a kid and a tag-along; loyal to Soda above all else.

PART 3: CHARACTER ANALYSIS & SYNTHESIS QUESTIONS

Directions: Answer the following analytical prompts using specific details from Chapter 1.

1. Foil Characters (Darry vs. Sodapop): How do Darry and Sodapop serve as contrasting personalities ('foils') in Ponyboy's life? How does each brother express care differently?

2. Social Markers & Identity: According to Chapter 1, what physical items, styles, or behaviors define a 'Greaser' vs. a 'Soc'? Why is hair so central to Ponyboy's self-identity?

3. Internal Conflict: What makes Ponyboy distinct from the rest of his gang? How does his interest in books and movies create an internal conflict regarding his social class?
